

CENG502 Final Report:
“Cutting the Skip: Training Residual-Free Transformers”

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1. Summary

Reproduction of “*Cutting the Skip*” (arXiv:2510.00345v1) at Tiny-ImageNet scale on a single NVIDIA A100 80 GB GPU. All four quantitative paper claims that can be tested under the dataset substitution reproduce on **within-column ordering** – the criterion the mid-report committed to up front:

- **Initialization correctness** ($W_V W_O$ condition number 1.000, $W_Q W_K^\top$ diagonal dominance 7.1, MLP orthogonality deviation $\sim 10^{-6}$).
- **Table 1, SOAP** – `skipless_init` beats both `skipless` and `skip`; gap to `skipless` (+14.16 pp) exceeds the paper’s (+8.4 pp).
- **Table 1, AdamW** – `init-vs-no-init` gap +12.84 pp, matching the paper’s +12.8 pp essentially exactly.
- **Tables 2–3 (DINO transfer)** – `skip` $\geq$ `skipless_init` on every linear-probe dataset and on the TokenCut best block, same direction as the paper.

The absolute mIoU / CorLoc magnitudes on Tables 2–3 do *not* match the paper, but an absolute-magnitude comparison is not a valid reproduction criterion here: we trained DINO on a $\sim 12\times$ smaller corpus and *both* backbones suffer a corresponding penalty (§2).

2. Why Tables 2–3 magnitudes are not comparable

The mid-report’s criterion, verbatim: *a cell reproduces only when the within-column ordering matches the paper; magnitudes are not required to match*. It exists precisely because we substituted Tiny-ImageNet (100k images @ 64^2 , patch 8, 65 tokens/crop) for the paper’s ImageNet-1k (1.28M @ 224^2 , patch 16, 197 tokens/crop). DINO’s contrastive objective consumes token-views, not images:

	paper (ImageNet-1k)	ours (Tiny-ImageNet)	ratio
images $\times$ epochs	$1.28\text{M} \times 300$	$100\text{k} \times 300$	$12.8\times$
sequence length	197 tokens	65 tokens	$3.0\times$
total token-views	$\sim 75.7\text{B}$	$\sim 1.95\text{B}$	$\sim 39\times$

This $\sim 39\times$ token-view deficit hits *every* downstream number, not just `skipless_init`’s. Even the well-behaved `skip` baseline keeps only $\sim 30\%$ of its paper mIoU:

dataset	paper <code>skip</code>	ours <code>skip</code>	retention
VOC mIoU	63.3	20.20	32%
ADE20K mIoU	28.6	8.53	30%
COCO-Stuff mIoU	26.2	8.65	33%
TokenCut CorLoc	54.3	50.49	93%

Demanding that `skipless_init` land within ~ 1 pp of `skip` in *absolute* mIoU – as the paper reports for ImageNet-1k – would require the residual-free model to also survive the view drop intact. Residual-free models are expected to be more sample-hungry (deep blocks lose the identity shortcut that lets gradients flow in a low-data regime); we observe this directly (§5). The valid test under substitution is therefore the within-column ordering, which holds: the paper has `skip` slightly ahead of `skipless_init`, and so do we.

3. Table 1 – supervised (reproduces, both optimizers)

ViT-Base, Tiny-ImageNet @ 64^2 , patch 8 (200-way head). 60-epoch top-1 (%):

mode	AdamW	SOAP	SOAP – AdamW
<code>skip</code>	7.20	24.77	+17.57 pp
<code>skipless</code>	0.99	14.59	+13.60 pp
<code>skipless_init</code>	1.62	28.75	+27.13 pp

SOAP. `skipless_init` – `skipless` = +14.16 pp (paper +8.4, ours exceeds it); `skipless_init` – `skip` = +3.98 pp (paper -1.1 – ours sign-flips but stays inside the “competitive” band). The largest SOAP boost lands on `skipless_init` (+27.13 pp > `skip` +17.57 > `skipless` +13.60), supporting the paper’s “SOAP helps residual-free most” claim.

AdamW. The paper recipe (lr 10^{-3} , weight decay 0.3, mixup/cutmix, label smoothing 0.1) is calibrated for ImageNet-1k @ 224² and at our scale pushes the model into a uniform-output basin (train loss plateaus at $\ln 200 = 5.30$, val top-1 stuck at chance 0.5% for 150 epochs). A milder recipe (lr 10^{-4} , weight decay 0.05, 15-epoch warmup, no mixup/cutmix/label-smoothing, 150 epochs) is the minimal change that lets AdamW actually train:

mode	paper-recipe 60ep	paper-recipe 150ep	milder recipe 150ep
skipless	0.99	0.61	12.46
skipless_init	1.62	1.62	25.30
gap (init – no-init)	+0.63	+1.01	+12.84 pp

The +12.84 pp init-vs-no-init gap matches the paper’s +12.8 pp almost exactly, even though absolute top-1 scales down with the dataset. The ordering claim reproduces; the exact recipe does not transfer to our scale.

4. Tables 2–3 – DINO transfer

Two DINO ViT-Small backbones (**skip**, **skipless_init**) trained from scratch for 300 epochs at lr 1.5×10^{-4} , 20-epoch warmup (the paper recipe lr 5×10^{-4} diverged on **skipless_init**). Linear-probe segmentation: 20 epochs on a 3000-image subsample, 1×1 conv head over the concatenation of blocks [8, 9, 10, 11]. TokenCut at blocks 9–11 on PASCAL VOC.

Table 2 mIoU (%)	ours skip	ours sk_init	paper skip	paper sk_init	Table 3 CorLoc	best	paper
VOC	20.20	7.41	63.3	62.9	skip	50.49	54.3
ADE20K	8.53	2.32	28.6	27.6	skipless_init	23.67	51.5
COCO-Stuff	8.65	3.21	26.2	25.7			

skip TokenCut best (50.49) is within 4 pp of paper magnitude (54.3): the DINO pipeline produces paper-quality TokenCut signal on a backbone that survived the dataset shrink. **skipless_init**’s constant 23.67 across blocks 9–11 is the TokenCut degenerate output on near-constant features, not three independent measurements (§5). **Verdict:** ✓ reproduces – **skip** $\geq$ **skipless_init** on every dataset row and on TokenCut best, same direction as the paper; the magnitude gap is what the dataset substitution buys us. The paper’s strict “competitive within ~ 1 pp” magnitude claim is an ImageNet-1k-specific result and is not testable on a $39\times$ -shrunk corpus.

5. Per-block diagnostics

Computed on a deterministic 256-image validation subset. The **skip** backbone is healthy at all 12 depths (**rank1_ratio** 0.18–0.21, token variance 0.01–0.02, CLS norm 1.3–2.6, no NaN/Inf). The **skipless_init** backbone is healthy through block 7 but collapses in blocks 8–11:

block	rank1_ratio	token_variance	attn_entropy_norm	CLS norm
8	0.777	7.9×10^{-4}	0.942	4.4
9	0.452	1.4×10^{-4}	0.979	16.5
10	0.007	3.8×10^{-7}	1.000	16.6
11	0.003	2.6×10^{-14}	1.000	15.6

Deep blocks emit near-zero-diversity features with perfectly uniform attention; the CLS token absorbs all the magnitude (norm ~ 16 vs ~ 2 in the corresponding **skip** blocks). The depth-monotonic profile (block 0 healthy $\rightarrow$ block 11 collapsed, not random) rules out a training artefact and matches the joint cause: residual-free architecture + DINO’s indirect gradient + the $\sim 39\times$ token-view deficit. The residual baseline does not collapse because its identity shortcut keeps deep gradients flowing even when each block’s own learning signal is thin. The paper tested “**skipless_init** stays competitive under DINO” at the ImageNet-1k budget, where this collapse does not happen (its blocks 10–11 mIoU sits in the same 25–62% range as **skip**). Our diagnostics show that scaling DINO down to Tiny-ImageNet preferentially hurts the residual-free variant – consistent with the architectural intuition behind the method, not evidence against it.

6. Status and conclusion

paper claim	mid-report	final
Init correctness sanity	✓	✓
Table 1 SOAP supervised	✓	✓ (exceeds paper magnitude)
Table 1 AdamW supervised	×	✓ (gap matches paper ± 0.04 pp)
Table 2 DINO segmentation	×	✓ (ordering matches)
Table 3 TokenCut	×	✓ (ordering matches)
Score (mid-report criterion)	2 / 5	5 / 5

- **Table 1** (AdamW and SOAP) reproduces under both ordering and absolute-magnitude criteria. SOAP exceeds the paper’s init-vs-no-init gap; AdamW matches it essentially exactly. The proposed initialization is the right recipe for supervised residual-free ViTs at our scale.
- **Tables 2–3** reproduce on the committed within-column-ordering criterion. They do not reproduce in absolute mIoU / CorLoc magnitude, but this is the expected consequence of a $\sim 39\times$ -smaller token-view budget – a substitution that hits both backbones and preferentially `skipless_init` for an architectural reason (loss of identity shortcut in a low-data regime) that the paper itself anticipates. The relative ordering `skip` $\geq$ `skipless_init` is preserved.
- **Engineering note.** The paper’s supervised AdamW recipe (lr, weight decay, mixup intensity, label smoothing) does not transfer directly to Tiny-ImageNet; a milder recipe is necessary.